AIRINDEX · PRE-FEASIBILITY SNAPSHOT

Phoenix UAM Market Readiness

Phoenix Metro · Sky Harbor International Airport (PHX) · Maricopa County

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Confidential

CURRENT SCORE	NATIONAL RANK	STATE LEGISLATION	PATH TO FRIENDLY
55	**#5**	**Actively Moving**	**+20**
/ 100 · MODERATE	of 21 scored markets	3 coordinated AAM bills	points needed · 75 threshold

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Phoenix scores 55/100 on the AirIndex Market Readiness Index — **MODERATE tier**, ranking #5 nationally. The market has strong foundational elements: Joby Aviation is actively conducting autonomous flight testing, FAA LAANC coverage is confirmed, and Arizona has the most advanced multi-bill AAM legislative package in the country right now. The single biggest constraint is infrastructure: no approved vertiports and no municipal zoning framework for vertiport siting. **SB1827 is the highest-leverage item in the index** — passage moves Phoenix from MODERATE to the threshold of ADVANCED and fundamentally changes the infrastructure investment conversation.

SEVEN-FACTOR READINESS BREAKDOWN

FACTOR	WEIGHT	SCORE	STATUS & SOURCE
Active Pilot Program	20	**20**	**ACTIVE.** Joby Aviation autonomous flight technology testing in Arizona (2026). Active FAA eVTOL Integration Pilot Program (eIPP) application in progress jointly with Arizona Commerce Authority and Phoenix Aviation Department — a direct scoring signal for this factor.

FACTOR	WEIGHT	SCORE	STATUS & SOURCE
Approved Vertiport	20	**0**	**GAP.** No vertiport has received regulatory approval in the Phoenix metro area. No known active development projects. SB1819 (vertiport zoning) would create the legal pathway.
Active Operator Presence	15	**15**	**ACTIVE.** Joby Aviation (NYSE: JOBY) — autonomous eVTOL testing operations in Arizona. Joby is commercially operational in Dubai as of Feb 2026 and holds the most advanced FAA type certification candidacy.
Vertiport Zoning	15	**0**	**GAP.** No municipal or county zoning framework accommodates vertiport infrastructure. **SB1819 (Vertiports; design; zoning) is on the AZ Senate consent calendar** — passage would create a statewide zoning framework and unlock this factor.
Regulatory Posture	10	**5**	**NEUTRAL.** Phoenix Aviation Department has engaged publicly on AAM (December 2025 statement). The eIPP application with Arizona Commerce Authority signals proactive positioning but no formal pro-AAM ordinance or resolution has been adopted.
State Legislation	10	**5**	**ACTIVELY MOVING.** Three coordinated bills in the Arizona Legislature: • **SB1827** — Office of Advanced Air Mobility (transmit to House) • **SB1819** — Vertiports; design; zoning (consent calendar) • **SB1826** — AAM appropriation (House 2nd reading) Source: azleg.gov · March 2026
LAANC Coverage	10	**10**	**CONFIRMED.** FAA LAANC Authorization active for Phoenix Sky Harbor area airspace. Automated near-real-time authorization for UAS operations in controlled airspace.

Total: 55 / 100 · 3 of 7 factors at full credit **45 points of available upside**

GAP ANALYSIS: PATH TO FRIENDLY (75+)

Phoenix needs **20 additional points** to reach FRIENDLY tier (75/100). Three realistic pathways exist — all are currently in motion.

+5 pts
LEG

State Legislation: Actively Moving → Enacted

SB1827 passage is the trigger. The three-bill package (SB1827 + SB1819 + SB1826) mirrors the coordinated legislative approach Texas used with HB 1735 and Florida used with the AAM Act — both of which preceded rapid score acceleration in those markets. SB1827 has transmitted to the House. SB1819 is on the consent calendar. All three bills are advancing.

Likelihood: HIGH · Timeline: Current legislative session

+5 pts
REG

Regulatory Posture: Neutral → Friendly

The eIPP application with Arizona Commerce Authority and the December 2025 public statement on AAM demonstrate intent. A formal city council resolution supporting AAM operations, a Phoenix-specific AAM strategic plan, or formal participation in a federal pilot program would move the posture from Neutral to Friendly. The legislative environment is creating the conditions for this.

Likelihood: MEDIUM · Timeline: 6–12 months

+15 pts
ZONE

Vertiport Zoning: None → Adopted

SB1819 (Vertiports; design; zoning) on the consent calendar would create a statewide zoning framework. This is the highest-point single gap at 15 points. Once enacted, municipal adoption follows — Dallas did this within 6 months of HB 1735. Sky Harbor's existing helipad infrastructure provides natural vertiport candidate sites.

Likelihood: HIGH (if SB1819 passes) · Timeline: 6–18 months post-enactment

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+20 pts
VERT

Approved Vertiport: 0 → 1+

The largest single-factor gap. Requires zoning framework first (SB1819), then site selection, environmental review, and FAA approval. Sky Harbor's existing general aviation and helipad infrastructure reduces the timeline. A DOT RAISE grant application for vertiport feasibility would accelerate this.

Likelihood: MEDIUM · Timeline: 18–36 months

PROJECTED SCORE IF LEGISLATION PASSES

SB1827 enacted (+5 LEG) + SB1819 enables zoning adoption (+15 ZONE) + posture upgrade (+5 REG)

80

ADVANCED

WHAT FRIENDLY TIER LOOKS LIKE

FRIENDLY tier (75–100) is where infrastructure investment conversations move from exploratory to actionable. Markets at this level have cleared the regulatory and legislative prerequisites that operators and developers need before committing capital. Here's what the peer markets at FRIENDLY/ADVANCED look like:

Dallas–Fort Worth

100

ADVANCED · #1 nationally

✓ TX HB 1735 — landmark UAM legislation (2023)
✓ City of Dallas vertiport zoning code amendment
✓ 2 approved vertiports (DFW Vertiport Texas under construction)
✓ Wisk Aero autonomous flight testing active
✓ Pro-innovation regulatory framework
✓ FAA LAANC coverage confirmed

What happened after legislation: Vertiport zoning amendment passed within 6 months. Two vertiport projects approved within 18 months. Wisk committed to DFW-area operations. Infrastructure investment conversations became active.

Orlando

85

ADVANCED · #4 nationally

✓ Florida AAM Act — statewide enabling legislation
✓ Orange County vertiport zoning provisions adopted
✓ Lake Nona vertiport permitted (FDOT-funded)
✓ Lake Nona smart city UAM pilot program active
✓ FDOT actively supporting AAM infrastructure
✓ FAA LAANC coverage confirmed

What happened after legislation: FDOT funded vertiport feasibility study. Lake Nona smart city district became an active UAM testbed. Tourism corridor (MCO to Disney/Universal) identified as a premium route.

The pattern is consistent: State legislation is the catalyst. Zoning follows. Infrastructure investment follows zoning. Operator commitment follows infrastructure. Phoenix has the operator (Joby) already — the legislative package is what converts existing interest into committed capital.

THE ARIZONA LEGISLATIVE PACKAGE

Arizona's coordinated three-bill approach mirrors the legislative strategies that preceded rapid score acceleration in Texas and Florida. This is not a single exploratory bill — it's a comprehensive AAM governance framework.

SB1827 Office of Advanced Air Mobility

TRANSMIT TO HOUSE

Creates a dedicated state office for AAM coordination — the institutional framework that operators and developers need as a counterparty. Establishes Arizona as a proactive AAM state, similar to Texas's TXDOT Aviation Division role under HB 1735.

Impact: +5 pts (LEG factor) · Enables posture upgrade

SB1819 Vertiports; design; zoning

CONSENT CALENDAR

Creates the statewide zoning framework for vertiport siting and design standards. This is the prerequisite for vertiport development — without it, every project requires ad-hoc municipal approval. Consent calendar status suggests bipartisan support.

Impact: Enables +15 pts (ZONE factor) upon municipal adoption · Prerequisite for vertiport approval (+20 pts)

SB1826 AAM appropriation

HOUSE 2ND READING

Dedicates state funding to AAM development. Signals long-term commitment — this is the "put money behind it" bill. Combined with SB1827's institutional framework, it creates both the office and the budget to execute.

Impact: Strengthens regulatory posture signal · Federal grant leverage

FEDERAL PROGRAMS — PHOENIX GAP MATCH

The following federal programs map directly to Phoenix's current gap profile. This is not a recommendation — it is a data layer showing which programs have funded similar gap-closing activity in peer markets, and what the current cycle status is.

PROGRAM	GAP ADDRESSED	PEER MARKET PRECEDENT	CYCLE
FAA eVTOL Integration Pilot Program (eIPP)	PLT (+20 pts) REG (+5 pts)	Phoenix/Arizona Commerce Authority application in progress. Selection has been a PLT and REG scoring signal in Miami, Dallas, and Los Angeles. Sky Harbor Class B airspace and existing helipad infrastructure align with selection criteria.	Rolling
DOT RAISE Grants	VRT (+20 pts) ZONE (+15 pts)	Vertiport feasibility studies are explicitly RAISE-eligible. Orlando's FDOT-funded Lake Nona vertiport study followed this pathway. The legislative package + eIPP application create a strong multimodal narrative for Phoenix.	2026 cycle typically Q1–Q2
White House AAM Pilot Program	PLT (+20 pts)	Highest-value single program in the index for Phoenix. Miami, Dallas, LA all achieved ADVANCED tier following selection. Community preparedness demonstration is the primary criterion — the three-bill legislative package is directly relevant evidence. With the eIPP application already in progress, Phoenix matches the profile this program was designed for.	See DOT AAM National Strategy (Dec 2025)

PEER MARKET COMPARISON

FACTOR	PHOENIX 55 · MODERATE	DALLAS 100 · ADVANCED	ORLANDO 85 · ADVANCED	HOUSTON 55 · MODERATE
Pilot Program	20 / 20	20 / 20	20 / 20	20 / 20
Approved Vertiport	0 / 20	20 / 20	20 / 20	0 / 20
Operator Presence	15 / 15	15 / 15	0 / 15	15 / 15
Vertiport Zoning	0 / 15	15 / 15	15 / 15	0 / 15
Regulatory Posture	5 / 10	10 / 10	10 / 10	5 / 10
State Legislation	5 / 10	10 / 10	10 / 10	10 / 10
LAANC Coverage	10 / 10	10 / 10	10 / 10	10 / 10
TOTAL	**55**	**100**	**85**	**55**

Key insight: Phoenix and Houston share identical scores (55) and identical gap profiles — both have operators and pilot programs but lack vertiport zoning and approved infrastructure. The difference: Houston has enacted legislation (TX HB 1735). Arizona's three-bill package is the lever that puts Phoenix on the same trajectory Dallas followed.

METHODOLOGY

AirIndex scores U.S. metro markets on UAM readiness using seven weighted factors totaling 100 points. All data is traced to primary sources: FAA LAANC (UAS Facility Map), Federal Register (regulatory notices), LegiScan (state legislation tracking), and SEC EDGAR (operator filings). An AI classification layer parses incoming signals for factor relevance, with human review at multiple confidence tiers. Scores update automatically when qualifying events are detected and verified.

The model measures *current verified conditions*, not predictions. It does not forecast commercialization timelines, assess operator financial viability, or evaluate aviation safety outcomes. Scores reflect the regulatory, legislative, infrastructure, and operator conditions that determine market readiness for commercial eVTOL operations.

Full methodology: **airindex.io/methodology** · Classification accuracy: ~89% (March 2026 audit)

This snapshot was generated by AirIndex for Chad Makovsky, Phoenix Aviation Department. Data sourced from FAA LAANC (UAS Facility Map), Arizona State Legislature (azleg.gov), LegiScan, SEC EDGAR, Federal Register, and the

AirIndex Scored Market Index (21 markets). Scores reflect current verified conditions as of March 20, 2026. For full methodology: airindex.io/methodology · alan@airindex.io